

2025 Report

Growing Up Between Worlds

In a small coastal town in China, a group of children gathered for what they thought would be another ordinary summer class.

By the end of three days, many of them were sharing stories they had never told before.

Some wrote letters to their parents for the first time.

Some found the confidence to speak.

Some simply realised they were not alone.

This project began with a simple question:

What happens when children don't have a space to be heard?

1. The System Behind the Story

Many people have never heard of the **hukou system**, but in China, it quietly shapes millions of lives. This system divides citizens into *rural* and *urban* categories. It determines access to public services — including education.

For migrant families who move to cities in search of better opportunities, this creates a paradox:

- They live in cities
- They work in cities
- But their children often **cannot access the same schools as local students**

Instead, many attend **migrant schools** — institutions that are often underfunded, understaffed, and lacking in support systems.



A photo of migrant school and public school in Wenling, China. (Left: Migrant school Right: Public school)

At the same time, policies aimed at reducing academic pressure, such as the **Double Reduction Policy**, have uneven effects. This policy aims to reduce extra schoolwork and off-school tutoring by

illegalising them. However, while some students benefit from reduced workload, others — especially those already disadvantaged — lose access to the additional support they relied on.

2. Why Songmen?



This project took place in **Songmen**, a rapidly growing town in Wenling.

Wenling is not one of China's biggest cities — but that's exactly why it matters.

As a **third-tier industrial city**, it attracts hundreds of thousands of migrant workers who cannot access opportunities in places like Beijing or Shanghai.

By 2025:

- Over **678,000 migrants** lived in Wenling
- Songmen alone had over **32,000 migrants**
- The number of children was growing rapidly

填发单位：温岭市流动人口服务中心

单 位	Migrant Population Base		Migrant Population Base under the age of 16	
	Registered	Compared with last year	Registered	Compared with last year
太 平	22551	1.67%	1451	-5.23%
城 东	48663	-1.21%	4081	4.11%
城 西	26088	9.89%	2020	2.75%
城 北	56746	-1.90%	5336	12.55%
横 峰	77661	6.00%	7192	18.88%
泽 国	150683	4.29%	15693	3.30%
大 溪	101700	4.31%	11760	11.05%
Songmen	32398	22.68%	2589	20.64%
箬 横	23516	5.51%	3151	3.62%
新 河	26355	1.81%	3171	-3.12%
石 塘	13841	-15.89%	965	-3.31%
滨 海	9898	20.06%	1177	9.49%
温 峤	39682	8.15%	4239	6.35%
城 南	7382	15.11%	709	9.58%
石桥头	1713	13.07%	233	0.00%
坞 根	1531	-7.16%	136	5.43%
东 部	38343	18.00%	1806	34.48%
Total	678751	5.02%	65709	7.97%

注：1.统计时间截至本月20日（数据来源于《浙江省流动人口居住信息管理系统》）。

2. “上年同比” = (当年本月 - 上年本月) / 上年本月 × 100%。

A photo of the table compiled by the Wenling official government

Behind this growth is a quiet pressure.

Families are working long hours.

Communities are constantly changing.

Schools are struggling to keep up.

And children are growing up in between.

3. The Invisible Struggle

Before designing the project, I spoke to students, parents, and migrant workers.

Their stories were different — but connected.

One parent said:

“I work hard just so my children can have a better education. That’s all I want.”

A student shared:

“Our school is not as good. We try harder, but it’s still different.”

A local resident admitted:

“There is an invisible wall between local people and migrants.”



A photo of me interviewing a migrant worker

These are not just economic challenges. They are **emotional ones**.

活动小小声调查问卷

亲爱的同学：
你好！我们想了解更多像你一样经历过搬家、转学、离开家乡的同学的生活和感受，这份问卷没有对错，只是希望听听你的心里话。你的回答不会被公开，是完全匿名的！请你放心填写！

1. 你现在上几年级？你在哪个学校就读？（写在下方）
六年级

2. 你的家乡在哪里？（可以写城市名或你记得的地方）
台州

3. 你现在住在哪里？
地球

4. 你来这个城市/目前就读的学校多久了？
☐ 不到半年 ☐ 半年到一年 ☒ 一年以上

5. 你觉得现在住的地方像“家”吗？
☐ 很像 ☒ 有一点像 ☐ 不太像 ☐ 完全不像

6. 你会不会想念原来的家或地方？
☐ 经常会 ☒ 偶尔会 ☐ 很少会 ☐ 从来没有

7. 你有没有觉得自己不太属于现在的学校或社区？
☐ 有时候会这样觉得 ☒ 偶尔会 ☐ 很少会 ☐ 从来没有

8. 在学校里，你有没有可以说心里话的朋友？
☐ 有好几个 ☐ 有一个 ☐ 不是很确定 ☒ 没有

9. 你觉得自己和同学相处得怎么样？
☐ 很好，我很喜欢他们 ☐ 还可以，有时候会孤单 ☐ 不太好，不太有人懂我 ☒ 我经常一个人

10. 你觉得你能自由地表达自己的想法和感受吗？
☐ 可以，很自在 ☒ 一般，得看情况 ☐ 不太行，有点怕说错话 ☐ 完全不敢说

11. 你现在和爸爸妈妈住在一起吗？
☒ 是的 ☐ 否，有一方不在身边 ☐ 否，他们都不在身边

12. 你觉得爸爸妈妈理解你吗？
☐ 很理解 ☐ 有时理解，有时不理解 ☐ 不太理解 ☒ 完全不理解

13. 你希望和父母或家人多交流吗？
☒ 很希望 ☐ 还好 ☐ 不太需要 ☐ 不知道

14. 当你难过或有烦恼时，你通常会：（可多选）
☐ 和家人说 ☐ 和朋友说 ☐ 自己一个人想办法 ☒ 不知道该怎么办 ☐ 写下来或画出来

15. 如果有一个为期三天的活动，你最想参加哪些类型的内容呢？（可多选）
☒ 写作/故事创作 ☐ 音乐（唱歌、乐器） ☐ 绘画/手工 ☐ 运动（比如羽毛球、跑步、跳绳等） ☒ 桌游/小游戏（比如狼人杀、剧本杀） ☒ 户外活动（比如集体游戏、寻找线索） ☐ 我不确定，看看大家都玩什么 ☐ 其他：

16. 如果可以自己设计一个活动，你希望是什么样的？
人不要太多，不要很吵

17. 如果可以改变一件事，让你现在的生活变得更好，你最希望改变什么？
生活环境家境

谢谢你认真填写！你的每一个回答对我们都很重要，希望你每天都能开心、被理解、被关心！

Photo of the survey given to the group of students

Answer of the students vs Number of People

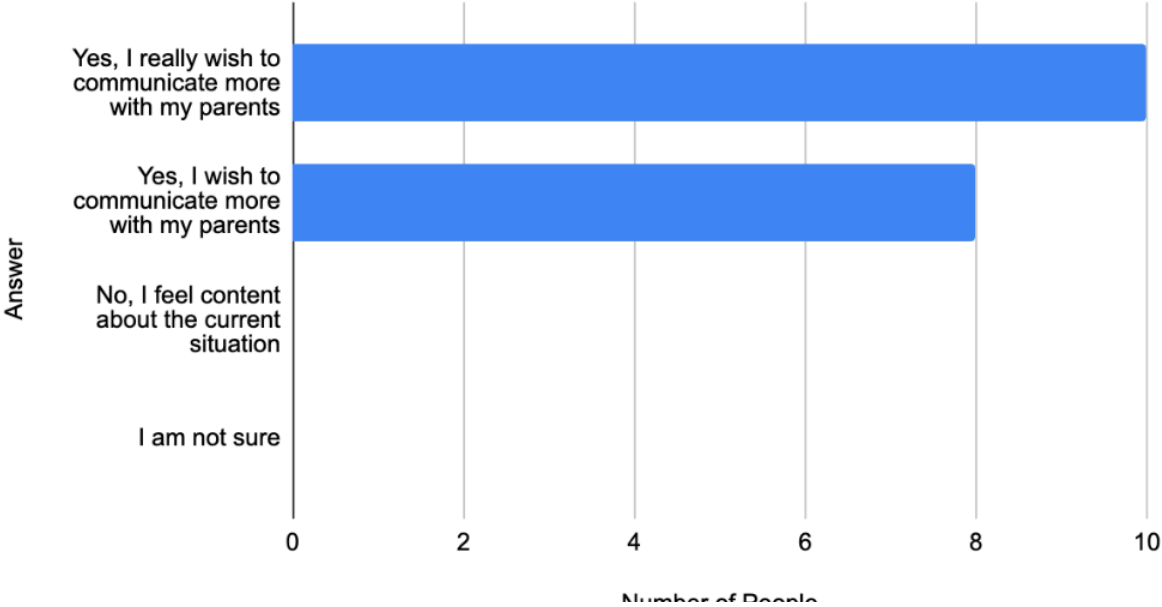


Figure 4: Chart showing the students' answer on the question: Do you feel that your parents understand you in life and studies?⁶

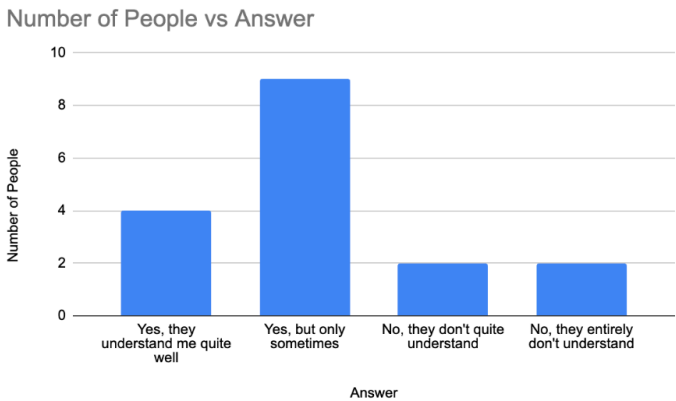


Figure 5: Charts showing the answer to the question: Do you feel confident when communicating?⁷

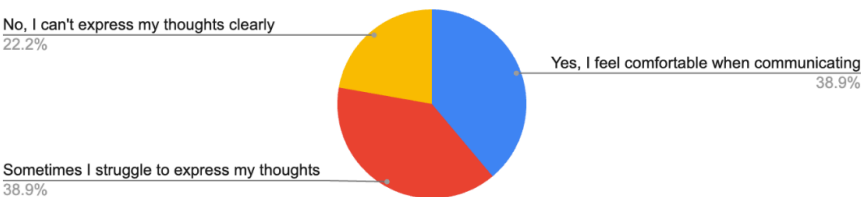
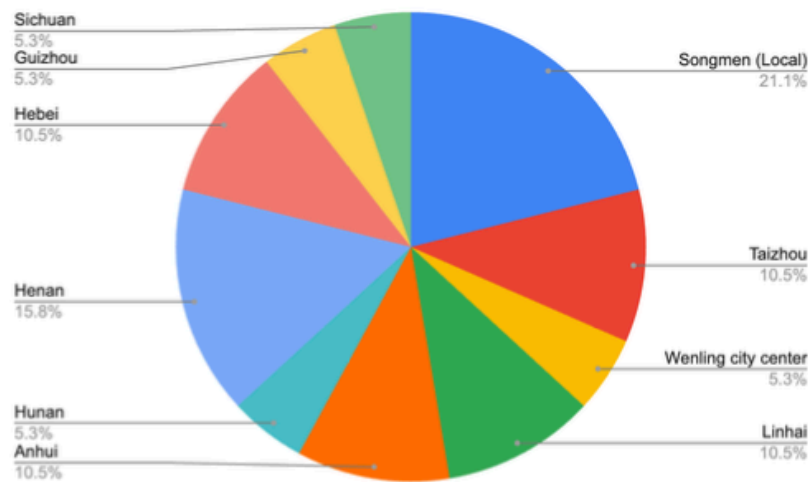


Figure 9: A pie chart showing the places of origin of the participants¹²



From surveys with students aged 9–14, several patterns emerged:

- Many wanted to **talk to their parents more**, but didn't know how
- Many felt **misunderstood**, especially about school
- Some lacked **confidence to speak in front of others**
- Most identified **family and academic pressure** as the biggest stress in their lives

These children were not lacking ability

They were lacking **space** — space to express, to connect, and to be understood.

4. The Project

A Different Approach to Well-being

This project was a **three-day intervention** designed to support the well-being of migrant and left-behind children.

Instead of lectures, we used **games, storytelling, and creative activities**.

Who It Was For

- 20 students
- Ages 9–14
- Migrant and left-behind backgrounds
- Summer care programme in Songmen

What We Focused On

We identified three key areas where small changes could make a difference:

1. **Relationships with parents**
2. **Connections with peers**
3. **Confidence in communication**

5. What We Did (Activities)

Activities	Explanation
The tree of expressions	Students were asked to put a sticky note on the tree with their feelings written before and after every day.
Name tag: “Who are you?”	Students were asked to create their own name tag with creative art ideas and introduce themselves.
Set the tone: Scenario acting	Volunteers set the tone for the three-day activities, including respectful language, inclusion of everyone and conflict mediation. This is achieved in a fun way with volunteers acting out a scenario and the students answering.
Who’s the spy?	The volunteers tell every child secretly of their scenario, and they have to say one sentence related to that scenario. We had two scenarios: 1. One thing you want to say to your mother/One thing you want to say to the store owner. 2. What is your biggest fear/ What is your biggest dream?
Creative story telling: story relay	We start the story with “Today, I woke up and opened the window”, every participant adds one sentence to the story.
Musical chairs with drumbeats	We have the chairs in a circle, facing outwards. The students distribute around the circle, when the drumbeat stops, they have to find a chair. There will always be one chair less than the remaining participants.
Whisper relay	Also known as the telephone game. The students asked to line up as groups, the first student hears one sentence, they have to whisper to the next person in line to pass on the message until the last student tells us what they heard.
“You are my sunshine” Song teaching	
Hangman	After teaching the students positive english words, we had a hangman competition between groups.
Emotional manage strategies	With games like “imagine a bubble” (when feeling losing control of emotions, close eyes and imagine a bubble slowly rising up and pop in mid-air) and discussions, we hope to strengthen their management with emotions.
Life journey map	Students are asked to draw a lifeline map of the highlights and sad times of their life.
Movie: “Coco”	
Reflection discussion: “What is love”	After the movie, we had discussions on what love is, had students divided into small groups and shared experiences.
A letter of love	After the discussion, the students were asked to write a letter to someone you feel grateful for, expressing love with words we learned in the discussion.
Pictionary	Students are told of a scenario or word related to emotion, leisure activities etc, and they would try to act it out with body language while the rest of the participants would guess the word.

Expectations: Who I will be in ten years time	Students were asked to write on a piece of paper about who they want to be in 10 years time, their dreams and hopes for the future.
Collective birthday	We had a collective surprise birthday for everyone, with a big cake to share. This is at the end of our three-day intervention. We noticed that most of the students have never had a birthday.

Day 1 — Building Belonging

- Expression Tree (sharing feelings anonymously)
- Identity activities (“Who are you?”)
- Storytelling games

Goal: Create trust and a sense of group identity

Day 2 — Finding a Voice

- Communication games (Whisper Relay, Musical Chairs)
- Emotional awareness exercises
- Life Journey Mapping

Goal: Encourage expression and confidence

Day 3 — Understanding Love and the Future

- Film discussion (*Coco*)
- Letter writing to family
- Future aspirations activity
- Collective birthday celebration

Goal: Strengthen emotional connection and reflection

6. What Changed

The transformation wasn’t dramatic — but it was real.

At the start, many students were quiet, hesitant, even resistant.

One student wrote:

“I thought this would be boring.”

By the end of the first day:

“Now I feel happy.”

Another student initially refused to participate, saying:

“I don’t care about my life.”

Later, he asked for a second chance — and shared his story.

Participation grew.

Voices became louder.

More than half the students wrote letters expressing gratitude — many to parents or grandparents they rarely spoke to openly.

Most importantly, this project created a safe space for the students to explore and discuss about their reality.

For planning for 2026, please [click here](#).

For more Stories that happened in the process, please [click here](#).

2026 Planning

8. From First Project to Next Steps

The first version of this project was implemented in the summer of 2025, focusing on well-being education for migrant students in Songmen, Wenling.

The response from students was overwhelmingly positive. Many showed genuine interest, engagement, and emotional openness throughout the activities. The project successfully created a short-term impact — students participated actively, built connections, and began expressing themselves more freely.

However, it also became clear that meaningful change requires more than a short intervention.

Due to **systemic constraints**, the project was limited in its long-term impact. These challenges included:

- **Limited funding**, restricting the number of students who could participate
- **Short duration**, making it difficult to sustain emotional and behavioural changes
- **Limited integration with local systems**, due to unfamiliarity with community structures and organisations

These limitations highlighted an important reality:

Creating real change requires continuity, structure, and deeper integration with the community.

9. What We Are Improving

Building on these insights, the next phase of the project focuses on expanding both **depth and sustainability**.

1. Integrating Extra-Curricular Activities. opweirpoiwe

Students consistently expressed interest in:

- sports
- art
- music
- reading

However, due to limited resources, they rarely had access to these opportunities.

By integrating **extra-curricular activities** into the programme, the project aims to:

- improve overall engagement
- support emotional well-being
- build confidence through diverse forms of expression

These activities are not just “add-ons” — they are essential to **holistic education**.

2. Developing a Structured Well-being Curriculum

Rather than a one-time intervention, the project will develop a **clear and adaptable well-being curriculum**.

This will:

- provide **consistent content** for future teaching
- allow the programme to be **replicated and scaled**
- ensure **long-term impact beyond individual sessions**

The goal is to move from **activity-based intervention** → **sustainable educational model**.

3. Using Media to Amplify Impact

With students’ consent, the project will incorporate:

- documentaries
- short videos
- visual storytelling

This serves multiple purposes:

- **raising awareness** of migrant students’ experiences
- **attracting funding and support**
- giving students a platform to **share their voices**

In addition, students may:

- showcase and sell their handmade work
- contribute to sustaining the project financially
- build confidence through creative ownership

10. The Next Phase

The next stage of this project expands its focus from short-term well-being to **long-term educational quality**.

Aligned with the **United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (Quality Education)**, the project aims to:

- combine **well-being education** with
- **creative and extra-curricular learning opportunities**

This includes:

- physical activities
- music and arts
- creative writing and literature
- continued emotional and social development